

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*The Gospel of Life ~
The Gospel According to Etty Hillesum
October 5, 2025*



"The Quiet Room" by Sir George Clausen, 1929

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert
TBD

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Esme & Lulu Gregoropoulos

Those who have known the strains of human life,
the heavy burdens of injustice,
or the perils of uncertainty,
come and tell again the story of God.

*May our hearts be made alive with memories of restoration.
May our mouths be filled with testimonies of hope.*

Our spirits are renewed through Sacred witness.
We remember the prophets – their truth offers freedom.
We remember Jesus – whose love transforms.
We remember those who persisted – their courage compels.

*With the joy of this ancient story that delivers and uplifts,
this morning we welcome the presence of God in our midst.*

[enfleshed]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Come, See the Fullness

BUNESSAN

God the Creator gave in abundance
All of the wonder we now behold;
Colors of glory, everyday beauty,
Echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall,
Love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.
Love formed the flowers, called for the living;
Marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – Life we've been given;
Beauty and promise, myst'r'y and hope.
Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose;
Friends for the keeping, strength for the road.

Open your hearts wide, teach us your wisdom
Lest our days pass by empty and small.
May we be witness with your creation –
To your great kindness given to all.

-Lyrics by Peggy Haymes

***Prayer of Awareness**

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

O God, all people are your Beloved,
across races, nationalities, religions,
sexual orientations, gender identities and expressions.
We are all manifestations of your image,
bound together in an inescapable network of mutuality,
and tied to a single garment of destiny.
You call us into your unending work
of justice, peace, and love.

May we know your presence among us now:
May we delight in our diversity
that offers glimpses of the mosaic of your beauty.
Strengthen us with your steadfast love and
transform our despairing fatigue into hope-filled action.

Under the shadow of your wings in this hour,
may we find rest and strength, renewal and hope.
We ask this, inspired by those who walked
with you through the ages.

Amen and amen!

-[adapted from Rev. Dr. Cari Jackson, Founder and Director
of the Center for Spiritual Light, New York City]

***Introit**

“Over My Head”
Commonwealth, Brandon Harris, *Director*

SPIRITUAL, arr. ADAM & MATT PODD

***The Lord's Prayer**

Esme & Lulu Gregoropoulos

*Eternal Spirit, Earth Maker, Pain-Bearer, Life-Giver,
Source of all that is and that shall be,
Father and Mother of us all,
Loving God, in whom is heaven:
The hallowing of your name echo through the universe!
The way of your justice be followed by the peoples of the world!
Your heavenly will be done by all created beings!
Your commonwealth of peace and freedom sustain our hope and come on earth.
With the bread we need for today, feed us.
In the hurts we absorb from one another, forgive us.
In times of temptation and test, strengthen us.
From trials too great to endure, spare us.
From the grip of all that is evil, free us.
For you reign in the glory of the power that is love, now and forever.
Amen.*

[pmoore/newzealandprayerbook]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

Peace where there is war
healing where there is hurt
memory where we have forgotten the other.
Vision where there is violence
light where there is madness
understanding where we have silenced the other.
Comfort where there is sorrow
tears where there is hardness
laughter where we have missed life's joy
laughter when we remember the joy. [jphilipnewell]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Baptism Song

"We Are"
Cathedral Choir

YSAYE BARNWELL

Baptism of Raven Amortencia Gonzalez Villegas

Readings from the Wisdom of our Tradition *from the Book of Esther* **Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz**

When they told Mordecai what Esther had said, Mordecai told them to reply to Esther, "Do not think that in the king's palace you will escape any more than all the other Jews. For if you keep silent at this time, relief and deliverance will rise for the Jews from another place, but you and your father's family will perish. Who knows? Perhaps you have come to royal dignity for just such a time as this."

This is the memory of the people.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

Eternal God, we remember those who have brought us to this place,
who have labored with You,
who have labored for us,
to make a way out of no way,
dreaming dreams and visioning visions,
both ancient and new.

We give thanks for that great cloud of witnesses
those who whisper their wisdom in stories, songs, and poems,
those who gave birth to movement and moments
of liberation
of healing
of justice
of love.

On this day, we remember and honor the legacies of resistance
to evil, injustice, and oppression
that have empowered our being
and invited our becoming.

Liberating God, call us to courage and make us capable of radical solidarity.
We are not left powerless.
Every day there are openings.
Every day a chance to choose what is right.
Every day an opportunity to repattern the world.

God, forever before us and behind us,
and for those who walk beside us,
we give you thanks. [adapt. /enfleshed]

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

“We Shall Walk Through The Valley” SPIRITUAL, arr. UNDINE SMITH MOORE
Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

Sermon

Rev. Lehman & Dr. Ianthe Marini
The Gospel According to Ettý Hillesum

Words for Reflection

~Blessed are you who bear witness in these times, for from your lives flow a balm for all wounds.~

Invitation to Generosity

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Through ordinary practices, we live God's dreams into being.
One simple choice at a time:
To imagine. To share. To mend. To be held accountable. To learn.
In gratitude for the grace that enables this freedom, we now give from our resources
for the work of this church, in our time and place. [adapt/enfleshed]

Offertory

"Agnus Dei" from *Mass In A Time Of War*
Cathedral Choir

JOSEPH HAYDN

"Lamb of God who feels our suffering, have mercy on us, grant us peace."

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

*Prayer of Offering

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

God of Compassion, we bring together our offerings fully aware
that our lives in these days hold both sorrow and joy.
In the days to come, help us to hold tight to the hope of what could be,
even as we do not turn from the grief and anger over the struggles of this time.

As we dream of futures alive with justice, may we be faithful to the present reality.
Faithful with our resources. Faithful to truth. Faithful in love and care for our neighbor.
May it ever be so.

Amen and Amen.

[adapt/enfleshed]

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

Inspired by the hands of hope
working, healing, holding, sustaining,
we go from this place to embrace
the task that is ours.

***May our hearts
be strong for the work we find.***

May our minds
be open to the challenges
it will provide us.

***May our bodies
be ready when the call comes
so that no one is ever
left behind.***

On this promise we stand,
as those who understand this world too clearly
and yet would have it
no other way.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"My God Is A Rock"
Cathedral Choir

SPIRITUAL, arr. KEN BERG

***Hymn for the Journey**

My Life Flows On

ENDLESS SONG

My life flows on in endless song, above earth's lamentation;
I hear the sweet, though far off hymn that hails a new creation.
Through all the tumult and the strife, I hear the music ringing:
It finds an echo in my soul - how can I keep from singing?

What through my joys and comforts die, I know the truth is living.
What through the shadows gather round, songs in the night they're giving.
No storm can shake my utmost calm, while to that rock I'm clinging.
Since Love commands both heaven and earth, how can I keep from singing?

I lift my eyes the cloud grows thin, I see the blue above it,
And day by day this pathway smooths, since first I learned to love it.
The peace of God makes fresh my heart, a fountain ever springing.
All things are mine since Love is here, how can I keep from singing?

[lyrics/adptlvf]

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence
Paseo de Gracia from *Gaudi* (Parsons/Woolfson)

Inside The Music

"TBD"